

Chapter 103 - Awakening

Three months later, at a VIP ward in the rehabilitation center of a private hospital under Beijing's Yan Corporation.

The ward was quiet, with only the sounds of operating medical equipment and the occasional turning of book pages breaking the silence.

Yan Lin was wearing glasses and carefully reading the knowledge in the book she held. She wasn't sitting on the comfortable, spacious sofa nearby, but had instead placed a chair extremely close to the hospital bed, where she currently sat.

Although she was reading seriously, she would turn her head from time to time to check on the condition of the person on the bed.

It had been a full three months since Feng Yue had collapsed and nearly died. During these three months, Yan Lin had done everything she could, only to receive from the doctors a single sentence: "Her body has no problems, but the time of awakening is uncertain."

Feng Yue was kept alive by a thread of breath, and Yan Lin was also kept alive by this same thread.

Yan Lin read her book to the last page, took off her glasses, put down the book, and instead earnestly gazed at the person on the hospital bed.

Three months wasn't long or short, but at least the adults at home had quietly accepted in their hearts that Feng Yue might remain in this vegetative state forever. Jiang Yu had even cried several times in places where Yan Lin couldn't see.

But Yan Lin still firmly believed that Feng Yue would wake up. Feng Yue definitely would wake up.

Feng Yue's body had become much thinner, able to survive each day only on the meager nutrition from the IV drip to maintain basic bodily functions.

Yan Lin wasn't much better off. Long-term insomnia and loss of appetite had also made her much thinner. She spoke even less than usual, saying fewer than five sentences a day, except when communicating with Feng Yue's doctors about her condition.

During these three months, Yan Lin hadn't left the hospital room for even half a step except to go home, and had even taken over Jiang Yu's bedside vigil duties.

She no longer cared about company matters either. Every day, apart from reading books aloud to Feng Yue, she would sit quietly in the ward, lost in thought.

Just like now, she quietly looked at Feng Yue, and as she watched, her thoughts drifted to who knows where.

When Jiang Shu Yu pushed open the ward door carrying a food container, this was the scene she saw.

It was as if that day, not only had Feng Yue collapsed, but Yan Lin's soul had also been lost.

Jiang Shu Yu still clearly remembered that night when Yan Lin had driven home in a hurry, and the first thing she did was drag her to Jintai Temple¹.

Jiang Shu Yu had thought the child was possessed and had been quite frightened, until she showed her the broken and cracked golden nanmu prayer beads and the talisman paper that had turned to ash.

They had knocked on the gates of Jintai Temple that very night, but Master Huiji, who had originally blessed the prayer beads, wasn't at the temple. He had gone to another province to attend some scripture conference and wouldn't return for three months.

Jiang Shu Yu pulled back her thoughts and gently knocked on the door to get Yan Lin's attention. "Ah Lin."

Yan Lin came back to her senses and turned to look. "Mom."

"Time to eat." Jiang Shu Yu looked at her gaunt cheeks and couldn't help but feel heartbroken. "Today I made dishes you like. Eat more."

Jiang Shu Yu opened the food containers one by one, revealing dishes that Yan Lin was familiar with and loved, but at this moment she had no appetite at all.

No matter how delicious these dishes were, they couldn't compare to what Ah Yue had made for her.

But Yan Lin also knew she couldn't let her mother worry, so she reluctantly picked up her chopsticks. "Thank you, Mom."

Jiang Shu Yu patted her shoulder. "Silly child, eat quickly."

Yan Lin took a few bites, then her movements of picking up food obviously slowed down. Jiang Shu Yu silently sighed in her heart, and after Yan Lin put down her chopsticks, she began clearing away the food containers.

After putting everything away, Jiang Shu Yu reminded her, "Ah Lin, according to the schedule, Master Huiji should return today. Do you still want to go?"

Yan Lin paused, then nodded.

"Alright, then wait for Aunt Jiang to come back before going home. We'll go again tonight."

"Okay."

After Jiang Shu Yu finished speaking, she left with the food containers, leaving only Yan Lin with her hands folded, lying against Feng Yue's bedside, quietly thinking about who knows what.

Yan Lin was suddenly afraid. She was afraid that after going, Master Huiji would tell her the same thing as those doctors - that Feng Yue had no problems. She was afraid that this last hope of hers would completely disappear.

A feeling similar to being timid about approaching home² rose in her heart.

But Yan Lin knew she had to make this trip.

Around five in the afternoon, Jiang Yu appeared in the ward looking travel-worn, carrying a large shoulder bag and holding a crumpled flyer in her hand.

"Aunt Jiang." Yan Lin got up to pour Jiang Yu a glass of water.

Jiang Yu nodded. "Ah Lin, thank you for your hard work. Did anything happen with our girl today?"

Yan Lin silently shook her head, and Jiang Yu nodded slightly, also falling into silence.

Yan Lin didn't want her to be too sad, so she changed the subject. "Aunt Jiang, did the lecture go smoothly?"

Yan Lin was referring to a lecture about vegetative patients that Jiang Yu had attended in a neighboring city.

Jiang Yu shook her head and forced a comforting smile. "How could it go smoothly?"

"Please take care of your health. Ah Yue won't be happy to see you like this when she wakes up."

Jiang Yu looked down at herself and nodded silently again.

What Yan Lin said wasn't false. Compared to before, Jiang Yu looked much more haggard. Although her clothing was still as exquisite and noble as usual, her spirit had declined considerably.

Since Yan Lin had something to do later, she didn't chat with Jiang Yu for long. After giving Jiang Yu some instructions, she went home.

Yan Lin changed clothes and took a shower at home, then got in the car with Jiang Shu Yu and headed to Jintai Temple.

Jintai Temple was Beijing's largest temple, not only with flourishing incense offerings but also very efficacious.

Yan Lin and Jiang Shu Yu had made an appointment and left their names, so they were directly let in at the entrance. The young novice who led them, upon learning that the two were devotees of Master Huiji, took them directly to the meditation room in the back courtyard.

The young novice said Master Huiji was waiting for them in the back courtyard.

Jintai Temple was located in expensive Beijing real estate, so the back courtyard was naturally renovated to be very modern, quite different from other temples.

Because the back courtyard mostly consisted of meditation rooms, Master Huiji hadn't waited for them indoors but was sitting at a stone table in the courtyard. Three cups were placed on the table, though two of them were paper cups.

Jiang Shu Yu had met Master Huiji before, so when she saw him, she politely greeted him.

"Master Huiji." Yan Lin followed suit and also greeted him.

"Please sit, both benefactors." Master Huiji was completely different from those profound and mysterious enlightened monks on TV. He was slightly plump, and when he smiled, he looked very much like the Maitreya Buddha in the main hall, with two streaks of graying long eyebrows hanging at the corners of his eyes.

"Benefactor Jiang, I heard from Huiyuan that you came looking for this humble monk three months ago. What was the matter?"

Huiyuan was the monk who had received the mother and daughter three months ago, Master Huiji's junior brother.

Jiang Shu Yu gestured for Yan Lin to take out the items, then introduced to Master Huiji, "Master, this is my daughter, surnamed Yan. She's the one who has something to ask you."

Yan Lin took out a small wooden box from her bosom, opened it, and placed it in front of Huiji. "Master, the items inside were what my mother came to request from you before."

Inside the box were scattered golden nanmu beads and a small bag of ashes.

Huiji glanced at the items in the box and smiled, asking, "Miss Yan, is the owner of these items currently safe?"

Yan Lin frowned slightly and only said, "There's no immediate danger to her life."

Huiji smiled. "If that's the case, then they have completed their mission. What questions does Miss Yan have?"

"Although she's not in immediate danger, she hasn't woken up. I know she was able to survive thanks to these two items, so Master, can you tell me the specific time when she will awaken?"

Huiji smiled and shook his head. "Miss Yan, you should ask the doctors this question, not come to this humble monk for answers."

How could Yan Lin not know this principle? If doctors could give her an answer, she wouldn't have come today.

"However—" Huiji continued, "This humble monk cast a divination today, meaning 'after extreme misfortune comes great fortune, gaining blessing through disaster.' This hexagram shows the image of fortune within misfortune - everything starts inauspicious but ends auspicious. When the time comes, Miss Yan's request will be fulfilled."

Hearing his words, Yan Lin felt the constant sense of panic in her heart suddenly diminish greatly, as if a heavy burden that had been pressing on her suddenly disappeared.

After Huiji finished speaking, he smiled, then stood up and said, "Please follow me, both of you."

Jiang Shu Yu quickly pulled Yan Lin to follow Huiji's footsteps.

The three passed through a corridor and arrived at the main hall in front. The main hall enshrined Maitreya Buddha, while the side room was filled with lotus-shaped lamps, their candlelight flickering and illuminating the entire side room.

"Benefactor Jiang, when you came before, I said this humble monk would give you a lamp. Now light it."

"Can it be lit for anyone?" Yan Lin suddenly asked.

"Naturally."

Yan Lin and Jiang Shu Yu exchanged glances. The latter nodded at her, then followed the young novice who was lighting lamps to write down Feng Yue's birth date and time.

The yellow talisman paper with the birth information was placed under a brand new lotus lamp. Huiji took a clean yellow talisman paper to the candlelight in the main hall, borrowed a flame, and lit the lamp belonging to Feng Yue.

Perhaps because the lotus lamp was new, that cluster of flame appeared very weak among the many lotus lamps.

"The lotus is a sacred object in Buddhism. Using the lotus as the base and the lotus heart as the guide, this lit lamp can illuminate any place. This humble monk will pray for this benefactor day and night in the temple, hoping she can find her way back and return home soon."

As Huiji's words fell, that weak flame flickered brightly, becoming much brighter than before.

And in some unknown darkness, Feng Yue faintly saw a glimmer of light. She struggled to get a clear look, wanting to open her eyes and see that glimmer of light clearly.

Feng Yue, lying on the hospital bed, suddenly opened her eyes. She also saw clearly what that glimmer of light really was.

The energy-saving lamp on the hospital ceiling was the first thing she saw with her eyes. The sound of pages turning beside her was the first sound she heard. The smell of hospital disinfectant at her nose was the first scent she smelled.

All of this indicated that she had returned to the human world.

Footnotes:

¹ "Jintai Temple" (金台寺) - The Buddhist temple previously mentioned in the story where protective items were blessed.

² "Timid about approaching home" (近乡情怯) - A Chinese idiom describing the mixed feelings of nervousness and longing when approaching one's hometown after a long absence, here used metaphorically to describe Yan Lin's fear of disappointment.